

Pakistani players are not picked in the IPL. I can honestly say what seems like a collective decision to not bid for Pakistani or Australian players was actually an individual decision of all team owners. Yes, there is terrorism and yes, there is a person from that country in prison in India right now. But does that mean I am pro-Pakistan? I am pro-relationships with all nations. If we don't have a dialogue with Pakistan, will it stop terrorism? Terrorism has no nation, it has a nationality of its own. After all, does anyone know where David Headley is from?

“The Mumbai film industry is not a homogenous unit. Everyone just wants to peacefully release their film on a Friday. Even I have not supported others in trouble.”

Q. Were you nervous before the release of *My Name is Khan*?

A. Nervous? I was shattered. I always say every film personality becomes very weak on a Thursday. There's no shame in saying that. It's not a question of bravery or cowardice. I was completely numb. I couldn't enjoy the most important aspect of the film, its release.

Q. Did you feel isolated in the film industry?

A. No. When have I supported them when they've been in trouble? See, the Mumbai film industry is not a homogenous unit. Ninety-nine per cent of us want the easy way out. Everyone just wants to peacefully release their film on a Friday. It's not out of fear or lack of goodness. It's just that the more of us who get into this, the more complicated it will get, the more it is us versus them. Plus more than 200 people work on one film, it's not about one individual. Every filmmaker holds back but it doesn't mean they are untouched by the controversy. Look what happened when Karan's film *Wake Up Sid* was attacked for saying Bombay, not Mumbai. I didn't speak up then. I didn't want to confuse things further.

“We get angry when a former Pakistani air chief appears in a Government advertisement. But there's an emotional outcry when Pakistani players are not selected for IPL.”

Q. Has anything good come out of this controversy?

A. Yes. I've known Gauri since 1984 but the most wonderful thing she ever did for me was when she went to Inox with Suhana to see *My Name is Khan*. I know how much it takes for her to go out and face the cameras. She's a very private person. Plus she'd already seen the film twice. Her logic was if so many people are braving the threats to watch the movie, she had to show the same faith. I was in Berlin and she didn't even tell me. I know it sounds very strange to say it after all these years, but she is a fine woman and mother. I'm really proud of my family.

good Indian. When Rizvan stands up in a Georgian church to sing “We shall overcome” in the new circumstances, is he assuring himself through the crisis, albeit without the Broadway musical touch? Just in the same way that his prolonged interrogation at Washington D.C. airport last year resonates in the first, quite stunning, scene of the movie.

At the end of the day, it was all about a movie whose theme is both universal and yet specific to India. If, for Johar, it was a chance to get out of the pigeonhole that people have put him in as director, for Shah Rukh it



**SHAH RUKH AND KAJOL
MY NAME IS KHAN**

was an important test of his acting skills. A chance to challenge the assumption that “isko itna hi aata hai (that's all he knows)”. “I hate talking about acting, because it is always in the rhythm of the movie.” If *Om Shanti Om* was an electric guitar note of madness, then in *My Name is Khan*, he was playing a “neuro-atypical mind, who could do less and say more,” he says.

His own somewhat “neuro-atypical mind” is now ready to fly, literally, in tights and cape, as a superhero in next home production, *Ra-1*, which, because of spiralling costs, he has decided to film in England rather than in the US. Short of actually playing cricket, Shah Rukh also hopes to encourage his team to win the IPL this season.

Nothing seems impossible now for the man called Khan.

with Nishat Bari and Sumalya Khan